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THEATRE ARTS

FILM ANALYSIS

Nollywood: A Critical Introduction

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How the Nigerian video film industry works, what its films argue about, and how to analyse them without importing a foreign standard wholesale.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- history
- production economy
- genre
- representation
- criticism

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A cinema made for video

Nollywood grew out of a television and video economy rather than a cinema one: cheap cameras, direct-to-video release, markets and roadside sellers, and an audience that watched at home. The boom of the early 1990s made the industry national and then continental, and the straight-to-video model shaped everything that followed.

By the 2010s the industry had split: a high-budget cinema sector, a streaming sector, and the older video market that still reaches the largest audience. Analysis has to say which Nollywood it is talking about.

The economy on screen

Shot on tight schedules and budgets, the classic video film developed its own grammar: long two-shots, a fixed camera, heavy dialogue, domestic interiors, and a strong reliance on music and on the star. These are production conditions visible in the form, not failures of craft.

A critic who measures a Nollywood film only against Hollywood will find it lacking in exactly the things it was never trying to do. Ask first what the film is trying to do, and to whom.

Genre and argument

The main genres - the family melodrama, the ritual and occult film, the crime and campus film, the comedy, the epic and the historical - are arguments about money, gender, religion, tradition and the city. The occult film, for example, is often a story about wealth and its price, and it is read differently by different audiences.

Representation matters in a cinema this large: who is on screen, who speaks which language, who is punished and who is rewarded. Count, describe, then interpret.

How to analyse a Nigerian film

Start with the conditions: budget, format, language, release. Then the story: what does the film want, and what does it fear? Then the craft: camera, sound, editing, performance, music. Then the audience: where was it shown, and to whom?

Keep a shot list for one sequence, a transcript of one scene, and a note on the music. Three pages of evidence will carry a better argument than thirty pages of opinion.

Distribution and the new platforms

The economics of Nollywood changed twice: once when video cassettes and then discs made the market national, and again when streaming made it international. Each change altered the form. The disc market rewarded volume and a strong cover; the cinema market rewards spectacle and a release date; streaming rewards the first ten minutes and a hook that survives a thumbnail.

Distribution determines running time, aspect ratio, sound mix and even the ending. A film made for a cinema screen can afford a slow opening; a film made for a phone cannot. When you analyse a Nigerian film, ask where it was meant to be seen before you judge its pacing.

The platforms also changed the criticism. Audiences now argue about films on the same timeline as the reviewers, and the box office is visible in a way it never was. A critic writing now is writing in public conversation with the

audience, which is closer to the theatre than to the old film review.

Sound, music and the Nigerian film

Music carries more narrative weight in Nigerian popular film than in most cinema: it tells the audience how to feel about a character, warns of danger, marks a flashback and seals an ending. A scene watched without its score often loses the plot, which is itself an argument about how the film works.

Sound is also the technical place where budgets show. Location noise, unrecorded dialogue and abrupt music edits are the marks of a fast shoot, and a critic should read them as conditions rather than as carelessness - while still saying when they damage the film.

Exercises

1. Analyse one five-minute sequence from a Nigerian film: shot list, sound, performance, and one claim about meaning.
2. Compare the first ten minutes of a 1990s video film with a 2020s cinema release: budget, grammar, audience.
3. Write a 600-word review of a Nigerian film that names its production conditions and judges it on its own terms.

Where to read more

Jonathan Haynes, Nigerian Video Films (2000)

Manthia Diawara, African Cinema: Politics and Culture (1992)

David Bordwell and Kristin Thompson, Film Art (any edition)

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